

Linux alternatives to Windows and Mac apps



Learn to Code with C++



How we found a WIIIIIIIDE Wii

Tech Monthly



UNBLOCK

Your school computers

Hear today's issue on how and rating ways to unblock school computers all the way from coolmath games to DVD, Web extensions and VMs.







Welcome to the first issue of the Tech Monthly Magazine



Anthony Hardes

Anthony is editor of Tech Weekly and is a tech hobbyist. His latest project is located:

Legolandgame .neocities.org

Welcome to the first issue of the Tech Monthly magazine! I am a tech hobbyist who uses Windows, Mac and Linux! This magazine is based on all of these OSes so no one gets left out. I will be planning to make one issue every month however, I have been very busy these past few months because of family but I'll be trying to make these every month. If this magazine gets popular, I will make a small tech weekly magazine and a free tech daily magazine to get your daily dose of tech news! I hope you enjoy this first issue and if you want to write for this magazine or give advice to me, contact Kitrssurfer by discord! Today's feature is rating ways and how to unblock your school computer. It includes everything from VPNs to dualbooting and the absolute correct Linux distro to use!

I hope you enjoy the magazine.

Adding colour to QR codes...

We all know what a QR code looks like, but it looks so boring. All it is is a special pattern of black and white squares and yet QR codes are still yet a widely used method to decode information. But what is stopping us from going further? QR codes are scanned with cameras anyway, could we possibly add some colour? We can! And it has been done many times before. But why hasn't people then heard of Microsoft tag (Top left fg1), Navilens (right) or Jab codes? Were they just overshadowed by QR codes? There is actually a fundamental reason of seeing wider use. Let's start by talking about math. A square on a normal QR code has 2 possible states, black or white. Becuase of this, one module can only represent 1 bit of information, if we added 2 more colours, each one would have 4 possible states. This would allow each module to store 2 bits of data, if we make it 8 colours, we can store 3 bits and so on. The more colours you use, the more info you can get and fit into a specific area, which means colour codes, like Jab codes, should be significantly more information dense than regular QR codes. However, the more colours you add, the harder you can tell them apart. And that's the huge problem. It's easy for a computer to tell the difference between black and white but red and peach can be a lot harder. The original colour the code was designed with can easily be changed by lighting of the room, image compression, white balance, or your camera settings. So I'm going to look at several different types of colour codes to see all of the unique ways to come up with to try and solve these problems. I've chosen some well known 4, which are high capacity colour barcodes, Jab codes, Navilens and HCC2D codes.

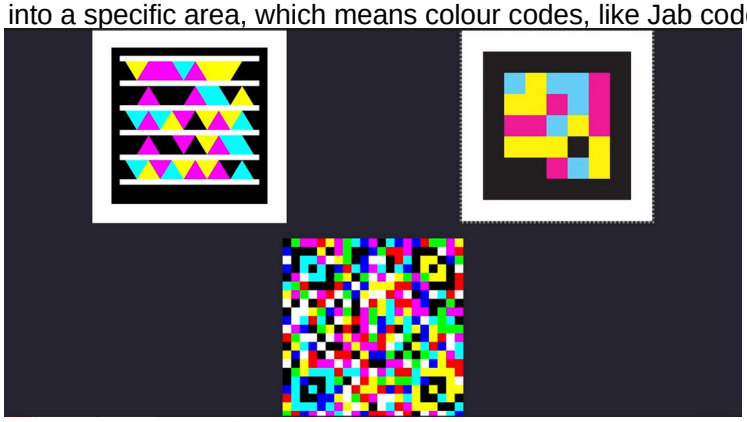


Figure 1: The unpopular colour barcodes out there

High Capacity Color BarcodesLet's start with High Capacity Color Barcodes, or HCCB, a technology Microsoft developed in the 2000s and later used as the basis for Microsoft Tag. Unlike QR codes, which use square black-and-white modules, HCCB uses coloured triangular symbols. Microsoft created the technology to increase information storage in a given physical space.The interesting thing about HCCB is that it doesn't simply take a QR code and replace every black square with a random colour. The entire information representation is different: Microsoft experimented with palettes of up to eight colours, allowing each symbol to represent more than a simple black-or-white choice. In laboratory testing, Microsoft reported densities of up to around 2,000 binary bytes per square inch using eight colours and a 600-dpi scanner.But there's a catch: More information per symbol doesn't automatically mean a better barcode. The scanner still has to correctly identify every colour, and errors can occur if the colours become distorted.Microsoft Tag was therefore intended for situations where putting a relatively large amount of information into a small printed area was useful. The technology was eventually used for tags that could connect physical objects such as advertisements, packaging and signs to online content.And we come to a theme that recurs throughout colour barcodes: capacity is not the be-all and end-all. A barcode that can theoretically hold twice as much data is not necessarily useful if it's twice as hard to scan.JAB CodeJAB Code takes the concept of colour one step further, using multiple colours to create a colour 2D barcode. The extra colours allow for considerably more information in the same space. But it also encounters the same problem: cameras don't see colours accurately, and the system has to compensate for the imperfections introduced by cameras, displays and printing.This is the fundamental trade-off we've seen in colour barcodes before:More colours → more information → more difficult colour recognition.Another interesting issue is that a normal QR code can often be recognised from its distinctive black-and-white patterns even when the image isn't perfect.Colour codes have to worry about yet another variable: what colour did that pixel actually become?HCC2DHCC2D (High Capacity Colored Two-Dimensional) takes the other approach, designed specifically to increase the data density of QR-style 2D codes while maintaining some of the robustness associated with QR codes. Research on the system dates back to around 2010.HCC2D's versions use four or eight colours, and the colours themselves carry information: for example, with four possible colours, each module can represent four states; with eight, eight states. In ideal conditions, that means a four-colour module carries two bits and an eight-colour module carries three. But HCC2D also demonstrates why it's important to choose colours carefully: its current specification has some carefully separated colours, with black and white being the extremes.

The four-colour version (in one of its standard palettes) uses black, red, cyan and white. The developers can also use different colour palettes for different situations, including screen and print applications. It's important to remember that a colour that looks good on a monitor might behave quite differently after being printed and photographed. Navi Lens may be the most interesting example in that its primary concern isn't simply to maximise storage capacity. Navi Lens uses a distinctive multicolour pattern to be detected by smartphone cameras from a distance while the user is moving. Its technology is particularly aimed at accessibility and navigation, including applications in public transport and other environments. It's more concerned with questions such as:"Can the camera find this marker quickly?"Can it recognise it while moving?"Can it determine where the marker is?" rather than "How much information can we fit into this tiny square?" Its design uses a multicolour pattern against a black background, along with a white border that helps define the marker and assist with geometric correction. Navi Lens says that its system can be detected from far away and from a wide range of angles without requiring the camera to focus on it in the way a conventional QR scan does. The whole idea of a "better QR code" becomes more complex, then. So why aren't colour QR codes everywhere?Having run through all four systems, there's a pretty clear answer. Colour isn't a free upgrade. Adding colours gives you another dimension in which to encode information. But the world isn't perfect: printers aren't perfect, cameras aren't perfect, screens have different colour profiles and images can be compressed or blurred. A black square turning slightly grey is typically still recognisable as dark. A carefully-chosen red turning a different shade of red or being affected by the surrounding colours is much more of a problem. That's why developers of colour codes have taken very different approaches. HCCB was focused on increasing density, but HCC2D combines colour with QR-like structures and error correction, while Navi Lens puts much more weight on fast detection, distance and positioning. The reason QR codes have remained so dominant simply isn't that colour codes are a bad idea: QR codes have an extremely useful balance between capacity, reliability, ease of use and the ability to be printed almost anywhere. Colour codes can beat them in particular situations, but once reliability is more important than theoretical capacity, just adding more colours isn't necessarily the answer. And the biggest question is: if colour can allow a barcode to carry more information, how much more information can we get before the added complexity becomes a downside?

I am planning to soon make my own system with Minecraft and Python.

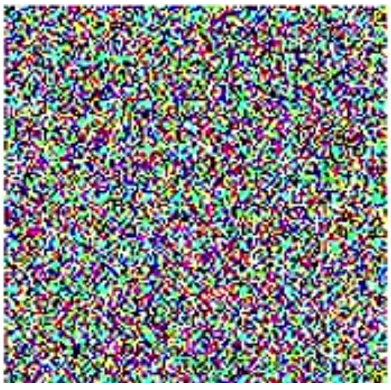


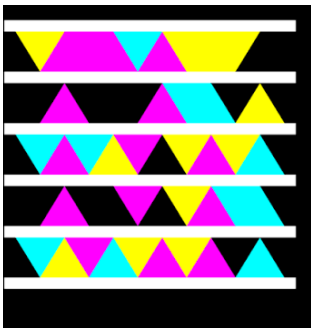
Wolf Byte

This article is inspired by Wolf Byte’s new YouTube video: I added COLOR to QR Codes.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OagFRgH3N8w

Or scan the QR code.. The jab code, Or the MS tag code. The JAB code on left is real though...







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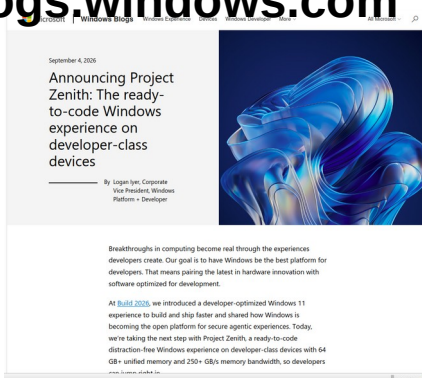
Get new and recent news about Linux and tech! Same news, different article. External Hyperlinks will lead you to non-gossipy sites.

THE MAIN HYPE



New Microsoft Project Zenith has been announced as a programmer friendly version of Windows 11. It will also provide a “distraction-free windows experience” for developers. Once it will be released, it will be available to the public and not just developers. See more.

Blogs.windows.com



September 4, 2026

Announcing Project Zenith: The ready-to-code Windows experience on developer-class devices

By Logan Iyer, Corporate Vice President, Windows Platform + Developer

Breakthroughs in computing become real through the experiences developers create. Our goal is to have Windows be the best platform for developers. That means pairing the latest in hardware innovation with software optimized for development.

At Build 2026, we introduced a developer-optimized Windows 11 experience to build and ship faster and shared how Windows is becoming the open platform for secure agentic experiences. Today, we're taking the next step with Project Zenith, a ready-to-code distraction-free Windows experience on developer-class devices with 64 GB+ unified memory and 250+ GB/s memory bandwidth, so developers

WHAT IS ON TODAY?



Raspberry Pi locks down Pi 5 RAM upgrades in firmware. Raspberry Pi added a feature in their firmware that restricts users from swapping RAM chips, sometimes even RAM chips of the same capacity from other Raspberry Pi boards. See more.

The walkthrough of how our weekly digest pulls those into one dashboard

→ Pricing for your size (20 seats) and the two-week onboarding timeline

Jeffgeerling.com



Jeff Geerling

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Raspberry Pi locks down Pi 5 RAM upgrades in firmware

Sep 21, 2026

Raspberry Pi added a feature in their firmware that restricts users from swapping RAM chips, sometimes even RAM chips of the same capacity from other Raspberry Pi boards.

Apparently there were people buying cheap 1 or 2 gig Pi 5s, soldering in some cheap and sometimes unreliable 8 gig RAM chips, and selling them as new 8 gig Pi 5s.

Now I totally understand where Raspberry Pi's coming from. They don't wanna support Pis being sold like this, because flaky RAM and dodgy resellers are a huge problem. Especially with how profitable can be in the current AI bubble.

But I also totally disagree with the way they're handling the situation.

The firmware update that disabled RAM swaps was actually from late 2024, two years ago. So you can't blame the RAM pricing situation for this.

Raspberry Pi is within their legal rights to lock down their hardware like this, but that doesn't mean we have to like it.

*We don’t publish daily... Yet

Samsung uses late iPhone Duo release as an advantage in advertising

Due to the early release of the Samsung Z fold 8, many people have switched already from IOS to Android. A good reason for this is also because that the Galaxy Z fold 8 does look very similar to the iPhone Duo. Apple's entry also brings a new competitor into a segment where Samsung already holds a large share. Counterpoint Research expects Samsung to account for 38% of the foldable smartphone market in 2026, while Apple is expected to take 25%. Samsung has seen a 10% increase in sales for its folding phone immediately following the announcement of the iPhone Duo. Samsung, in reaction to this. Made several tweets, with even Duolingo joining into the coversation, which Duolingo may sue apple for using "Duo" in the name and Samsung seems to be following along that route. People are buying the Galaxy fold instead of the Duo becasuse it looks so similar and it released earlier. However, in my opinion, this is just going to go the same way as the 2012 Samsung-apple Lawsuit. But the other Way round…

Facebook



Figure 1: The iPhone Duo (on the left), beside Galaxy Z Fold 8



Getty

Figure 2: The Samsung phone (right) copied from Apple

Part 1

iPhone 18… I have very mixed feelings

The iPhone 18! Now I have very mixed feelings about this phone. I don't usually upgrade. I like old tech. I still use an iPhone SE 1st gen as my main phone. The iPhone 18 looks identical to the 17, with just some new colours. So without further to say, lets get started!

Battery life. It is quite a solved problem at this point, unlike if you're me at 75% capacity. On the 18, you're already at 58% near 7 PM so it's not a big deal. However, the iPhone 18 Pro Max won in a battery test compared to the 17 and the Oppo find x9 by just 3 minutes longer than the Oppo, even though the Oppo battery is the worldwide strongest capacity. And the iPhone 18 that I was using was the smaller, physical SIM model with less capacity. If I had put an eSIM model, it would have lasted much longer than 3 minutes after the Oppo battery death. So this isn't good battery for an iPhone, it's world-class. Apple also did improve the charging speed on the iPhone. I know that battery life isn't that important compared to other batteries these days but it's nice to get all of the small details in.

Thermal efficiency. They keep talking about this in the apple announcements but I've never had an efficiency problem in my life! Ok that's a lie, I am on my iPhone SE 1st gen after all but I've known people who have an iPhone 18 and their old 15 and there isn't a frame drop or thermal problem in it! I bet that next up they're showing the same gameplay footage from an iPhone 15 on the announcement! However, if you play the sane racing game on an iPhone 14 it does lag so there is some , but barely any, efficiency through the releases. But that is the best part. You upgrading from a 14 to a 15 now means that you don't have to upgrade now. They keep talking about power, but how many games of PUBG Mobile do I need for it to start lagging? They are multiplying the AI performance but do they not realise how funny that sounds when Apple has the least sophisticated AI on the market.

Like why am I still struggling on absolute basics? It doesn't even correct grammar mistakes on voice to text. But there is a bright side. Improving thermals, even if they aren't a problem to us, are to Apple. It actually does extends battery life by working cooler. Now let's go to the dark side. Apple won't give us anything we want, then they come out with an action button when most people still just go to the camera app normally. Apple even know that is sucks because they disabled capacitive layer by default! And their material is a bad choice for advertising. Apple want me to buy the titanium iPhone Duo because it more durable and at the same time,



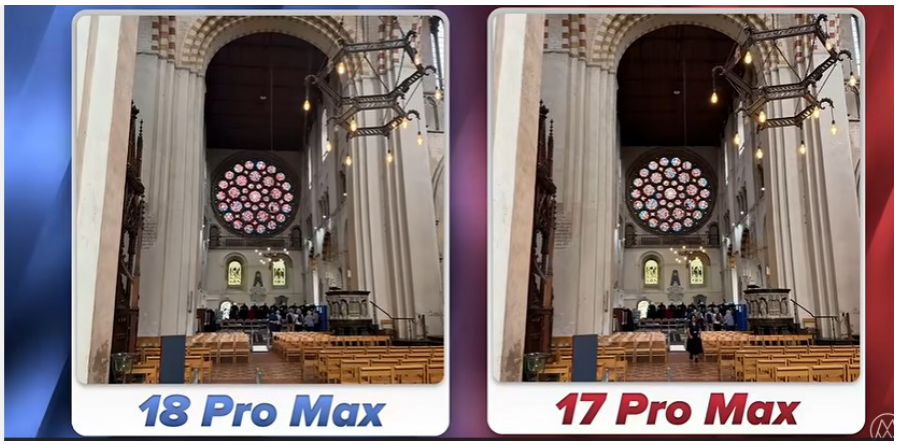
Figure 1: The iPhone 18 (left), beside iPhone 17 (right).

selling me on the iPhone 18 because they're saying "Ooh. It's thermally efficient!"

Colours. They make a new, stylish colour for the super-fans, but it's such a big trap once the next one comes out, and you have to buy that one because it's the new colour and the old colour now means nothing. So now the super-fans have to cough up and buy that one too.

Latency. I don't mean like opening apps is delayed, I mean literally everything Apple did is late. They could have put a privacy screen on the iPhone Duo. They even make a foldable almost 10 years late (see pg2 for more info). In recent advertisements, Apple says that photographers and professional film studios use the 17/18 pro but then how come Apple haven't managed to upgrade a single camera sensor? It's been 4 years since they have upgraded the camera. And I'll ask you a question, which photo looks better below:

YouTube Mr Whosetheboss



Most people will say the the 17 pro max looks better. This is because quality doesn’t matter.

How we found a WIIIDDEE Wii!

By **Anthony Hardes**
From **JakeCeption**

Today, we are going to tell the story of how we found a WIIDE Wii! Now these are a bit rare and I don't have one, but I know someone who has. JakeCeption from YouTube! All of this information will be referenced from his YouTube videos. It first came from an old image from the internet, but the more research he did on the internet, the bigger the hole was about to come...



Figure 1: The 4Gamers Wii speaker module

First he thought that it was just an old photoshop, but then there were more pictures of it, then he realised that it was a real product! It is a 4Gamers Wii speaker module. This isn't the only speaker product 4Gamers made! They made a PSP and a GameCube speaker Module! Then he saw a partially broken copy on Ebay and of course he has to buy one! The cables were broken but that is easy if you know basic soldering. The audio was really good considering it was made in 2006.



If you want to watch the video, you can watch it on the JakeCeption YouTube channel!

Watch JakeCeption now on YouTube

JAKECEPTION



I make dumb videos about the overabundance of obsolete tech and games I collect because I'm probably a hoarder.

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Thank you for reading







What's happening At the moment!

Killian Schrombeck
8d • Projects

Im so fast i already finished my project!

Legendary tech for android! 6.0 minium requirement , i wish i could put this on the google play store but it wont go out good because of the sdk.



0 2 Last comment 7d ago

Zayne Hayes
10d • Projects

using android 5 for WEEKS!

so i ended up using android 5 for almost 3 weeks (with freewill) mostly what i did was discord message and make musical.lys as i mostly use revivals on my older devices there wasnt much to check

2 2 New comment 7d ago

Zachary Staines
17d • General discussion

An absolute LEGEND.

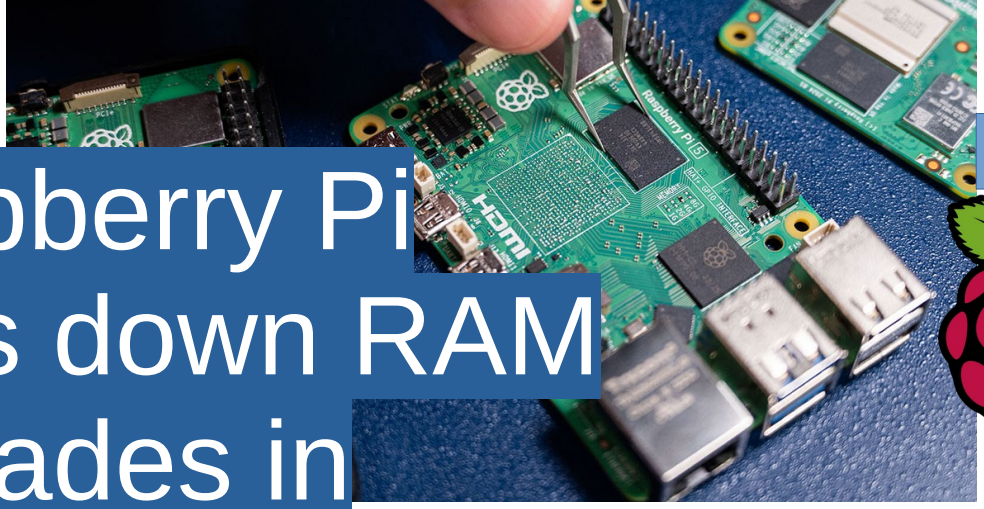
I stumbled across this video of this absolute legend. This is the Apple Power Mac G5 tower... the original cheese grater (I think?!) . Anyone seen of these for sale? lol



Elliot Smith
4d • New(er) Tech

windows 10 chinese government edition

so apparently the chinese government have their own special version of windows 10, and, me being me, I have to install it. anyone else know about this?



Raspberry Pi locks down RAM upgrades in Firmware

As the industry continues favouring surface mount devices over socketed components, contemporary Right-to-Repair (R2R) disputes revolve around firmware-based validation locks in the context of computer hardware repairs. With manufacturers implementing firmware restrictions on sub-component replacements, OEMs, repair advocates and lawyers are debating how existing law relates to micro-soldered ICs and board-level repairs.

The Anti-Parts Pairing Mandate. Parts pairing refers to a design concept, where the main IC (processor) or the bootloader firmware is programmed to recognize only specific peripherals (or groups of) during the system initialization, entering reduced performance mode or displaying warning messages in case of a mismatch. Right-to-repair advocates have successfully drawn lawmakers' attention to the restrictive nature of the parts pairing technique. California Right to Repair Act, Oregon SB 1596 and the EU Right to Repair Directive all mention explicit prohibitions of component level serialization.

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According to the aforementioned acts, OEMs are not allowed to deploy software or firmware provisions that prevent a technician from replacing a defective board-level component with a fully functional replacement.

Statutory Loopholes and Practical Engineering Considerations. From a regulatory perspective, the application of R2R laws to the IC validation firmware is far from straightforward. OEMs reserve the right to use all available technical means, including but not limited to IC-level validation, in order to preserve the "essential" features and safety requirements of their product, as long as they are not explicitly violating any consumer protection laws.

System Stability and Signal Integrity Calibration. With mobile SoCs featuring LPDDR5 6000 RAM, system stability, memory corruption and signal integrity concerns provide a sufficient basis for functional restrictions in the case of non-paired components. For each soldered module, the OEM engineers must program a set of trace routing and signal calibration instructions within the special device configuration tables.

Security and Anti-Fraud Requirements. The majority of R2R laws and regulations specifically address the concerns of independent auto repair shops and OEM breakers. Considering the prevalence of OEM anti-theft and fraud prevention systems in the consumer technology space, restricting third-party part replacements at the IC level can be seen as a measure to ensure system integrity and safety.

Scope of Repair Definitions (Modular vs. Component-Level). When crafting the R2R legislation frameworks, lawmakers and regulators primarily focused on battery packs, displays, sensors and other modular components. The existing body of laws feature considerable ambiguity regarding the applicability of R2R regulations to the micro-soldered BGA ICs. Thus, when attempting to apply R2R laws to firmware locks and soldered parts, lawyers representing either party have to rely on generalized definitions of technical repairability found in the Magnuson-Moss Warranty Act of 1975.

Current Jurisdictional Comparison. Region / Legislation Policy on Component Serialization Enforcement Coverage on Soldered ICs. California (SB 244) & Oregon (SB 1596) Explicitly bans software mechanisms that prevent independent replacement of parts or enter reduced performance mode upon failure recognition. Focus on Sub-Assemblies: Covers display and battery modules clearly; enforcement on micro-soldered board components remains untested.EU Right to Repair Directive Directs member states to outlaw hardware/hybrid techniques hindering independent repairs using third-party or salvaged parts. Broad Scope: Serialization restrictions are limited, but additional hardware engineering requirements are applied: safety, security and validation exceptions are permitted as long as alternative validation methods are available from the vendor.

U.S. Federal (Magnuson-Moss Act) Prohibits vendors from requiring licensed parts for warranty claims. Indirect Oversight Applies to Warranty Law: Consumer warranties cannot be voided by the OEM choice of replacement parts but not explicitly requiring vendors to offer flashing solutions for validation.

Industry Outlook. As more governments finalize their jurisdictions regarding Right-to-Repair regulations, it can be expected that the component-level serialization restrictions will be addressed in two ways: one focusing on traditional modular hardware and the other specifically mentioning board-level ICs and firmware provisions.

Considering the recent lobbying efforts from both sides of the equation, R2R lawyers are leaning towards the solution, which would require OEMs to unlock diagnostic and validation tools in order to allow independent technicians to perform module swaps without having to bypass any security or authentication firmware.

iStock

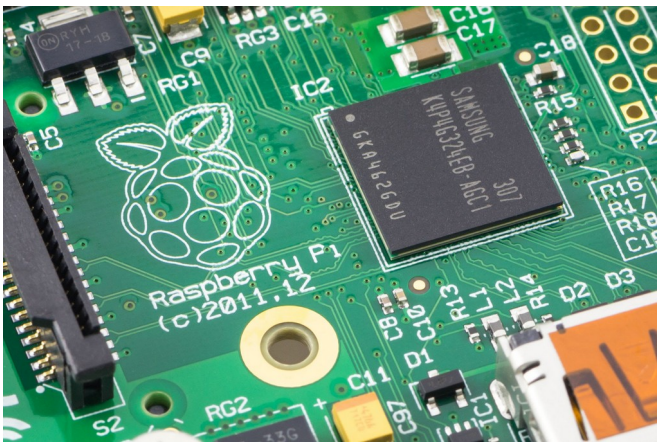


Figure 1: The Raspberry Pi

This article is inspired from Jeff Geerling’s new blog: Raspberry Pi locks down RAM upgrades in Firmware (https://www.jeffgeerling.com/blog/2026/raspberry-pi-ram-lockdown/) or scan the QR code

Microsoft’s NEW Project Zenith

By **Lift Excelsior**



Project Zenith: Windows 11 goes developer-focused Programmers, software developers, professional computer code manipulators, what would you say is the best platform on which to hone your latest app, game or utility?

Figure 1: The new desktop wallpaper of Project Zenith

Answers would vary widely depending on who you ask. Some may praise Linux for its stripped down nature and low system demand, or macOS for its ease of use and refinement. The good people of Redmond, however, think differently.

Enter Project Zenith. Announced on September 4th this year, Microsoft is chasing the script-savvy demographic, with a fully ready to code experience optimised for developer grade PCs. The platform will initially debut on AMD's Ryzen AI Halo, however support will be widening in the coming months. The brief was to showcase Windows at its very best, setting a new standard for what a software development class device can be. To make Windows the new benchmark operating system for serious programmers.

Project Zenith is moulded entirely around the exacting requirements of the software developer. Pre-installed programming tools - languages, runtimes, source control and productivity tools. Terminal and Visual Studio Code come pinned to the Taskbar straight out of the box, ensuring all the most essential tools are always within immediate reach. File Explorer

will show hidden files and long file paths by default. Start menu tips and Microsoft Account notifications are disabled to minimise distractions, enabling us software boffins to work at maximum efficiency, completely uninterrupted. Windows Subsystem for Linux, Microsoft's dedicated tool for running Linux workloads on Windows, has seen deeper integration into the Windows OS, bringing a built-in way to create, run and interact with Linux containers directly on Windows.

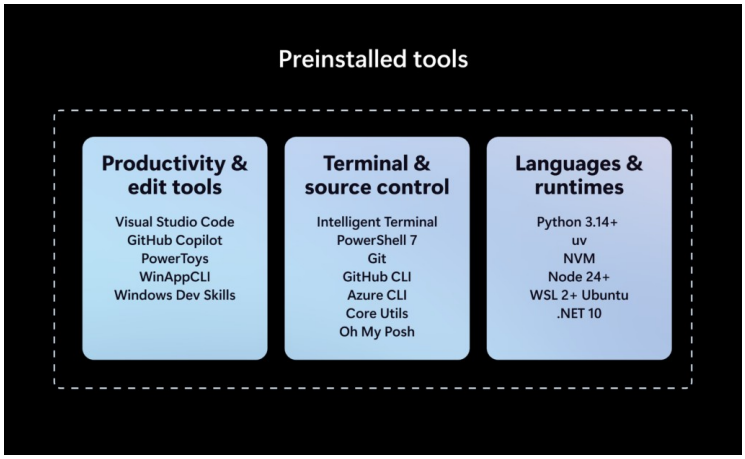


Figure 2: All of the default applications pre-installed on the OS

"We're entering a new era of software development," says Windows vice president Logan Iyer in Microsoft's blog. "Agentic applications are becoming more common, and developers need a secure foundation for building and running them. As AI models become more powerful, agentic coding workflows demand continuous compute. By shifting some of that intelligence to the edge, we are achieving token economics and transforming the developer experience: frontier models tackle frontier problems, while everything else runs locally at scale."

This will likely be pivotal news for those of us in the software development enterprise. Programmers can now work fluidly and unhindered. Large localised AI models may no longer bog down your entire system. Creativity can run even freer, enabling all kinds of new development possibilities.

However, it does make me wonder, is this really what Microsoft should be focusing on right now? Project Zenith is aimed at seriously powerful computers - up to 64 GB of unified RAM, no less. These are the kinds of systems that large AI and



programming projects demand. The thing is though, most of us aren't cutting edge software developers running top of the range, dual processor, memory by the boatload monsters. Most of us are still running regular old work laptops, with rudimentary specs and not a whole lot of fanfare to speak of.
I'm no serious software developer, so maybe my opinion would differ if that was the case, but I'm still not sure if this is the right priority at the moment. The baseline Windows OS is still incredibly bloated and demands copious resources for even the most basic of applications. In my opinion, attention should first be given to slimming down the regular Windows operating system, making it lighter weight and easier for lower end computers to run, especially given the current microchip crisis and how expensive powerful computer parts are quickly becoming. A dedicated developer platform is no doubt very beneficial, but personally I don't think it should be top of the agenda just yet.

Microsoft | Windows Blogs

All images and information to write this article are sourced from the official Microsoft announcement blog. This article has been carefully written based on the information given in the blog. (https://blogs.windows.com/windowsdeveloper/2026/09/04/announcing-project-zenith-the-ready-to-code-windows-experience/)

Lift Excelsior

“Hoarding imperfect PCs since lord knows when…”

A passionate tech enthusiast who lives and breathes computers, retro gear, gaming, and all kinds of hands-on experimentation

The Tech Debate



Cast your vote in by skool or:
scratch.mit.edu/projects/1233715816/embed
No sign-in required.

Cassette or CD





WALKMAN

Rating ways to UNBLOCK

Your school computers

Did you ever want to unblock your school computers? Well in this month's feature, we will be ranking the methods to unblock your school computer from in a random order! And after this feature you will know that a lower tier does not mean to not use it.

Opera

Nowdays, schools manage to block multiple browsers now. But if your school does not have that system, it is a really good way to unblock your school computer. That means that this way is a bit obsolete nowdays but it's definitely worth a try. Opera GX has a VPN but we'll talk about VPNs later.

External



This is by far one of the BEST ways to unblock your school computer! We come across similar things later which, in my option, are even better ways. All you have to do is install Linux on the drive and you're basically done! The Linux distro that I would use is Winux because it looks so similar to windows 11 that it will fool the teachers. For windows 10, I would use linuxfx 10.5. We'll talk more about these things in the USB sticks because they are THE BEST.

Replit

Replit is an online coding environment. It is useful for programming without installing anything locally. You can basically use a full development environment through your browser. However, they don't give you unrestricted access to anything, which will be a more common thing as we get down the list. I've had some people say when unblocking computers say "Just use Replit man!" but just doesn't work! Some people swore by it back in the day. The only reason it's not the un rateable tier is because some people apparently had it working but I tell you, 99% of the time it does not work!

Rating ways to UNBLOCK your school computers

AnyDesk

This will count as any remote desktops. A remote desktop allows you to control another PC through another piece of tech (PC, Phone .etc). The easiest representation with this is with the Raspberry Pi and Raspberry Pi Connect, which allows you to access the pi desktop through the website. Now if your school computer and your PC resolution is different, then there will be black bars on the size and it will be a bit blurry but not the worst thing in the world but it can become a problem. However, you do need your own PC and some people don't have their own PC or at least another device to run. There is also very bad latency but what else will you get that's better than this?

This section also applies to any other free gaming sites. Now this one's a classic! I have memories playing Poptropica on CoolMath Games and bloxd.io on CrazyGames at the back of class. I like these sites BUT they don't give you any unblocking feature so unfortunately it's going to be unranked.

Coolmath Games

VPN

I talked about this earlier because they work with Opera and more recently, Firefox! VPNs route your internet traffic through another server which can make a network filter see a different connection than it normally would. They are good when the problem is about the network filtering. BUT schools can block VPN services or detect their traffic and they aren't guaranteed to work so I'm not a huge fan of the VPNs. They are good for quick fixes and special use cases. I'll just say it's better than the browsers. Overall, this will be put in C tier It's good but it's not the majority where it will unblock everything

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Linux/ dualbooting

Now we are moving to the penguin! This part is basically just dualbooting. Dualbooting is when you run 2 operating systems on one computer and choosing which one starts when you turn it on. It is a bit different from the SSDs because the OS has to run on one hard drive or the drive slots inside the computer for it to be classified as dualbooting. It gives a completely different environment from the school system and the school's OS. There is a catch where you do need enough storage space to partition the drive. If your school computer does have enough storage space and you have an understanding of partitions, bootloading and firmware, then this is an instant A unless if the BIOS is password protected. However, I am still refusing to put it above SSD. Also, just like the external SSD, to not get caught, I would use a Linux distro that looks like windows (Winux for w11 & linuxfx 10.5 for w10)



These were pretty self explanatory but I don't think they were as common as they are in the present day. Node Unblockers work with JavaScript to use a server to fetch websites for you. I have never heard of these until very recently. It's essentially making a layer between you and the website you're trying to access. They're very cool because you can host it and customise it yourself but they are also so fragile and the school can just block the host domain. I would put it in C tier but you COULD have these running for a couple of months or weeks without IT knowing so I'm putting it in D tier because it's not a long term solution. My final words are that they can be neat, but you're definitely going to have some issues with it.



JavaScript

Now here we have JavaScript. This section is completely separate from node.js. You can write or modify a small piece of JavaScript code to change and modify a webpage. It's good for changing how a particular site behaves but they're very limited with changing your network or operating system. You can use this to open a cheat sheet and make the tab name and icon a Google Drive. In most cases it sucks apart from that one reason so this is going in F tier.

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Alternate Networks

This section is basically your hotspots. The way this works is that you would make a mobile phone hotspot and connect to it from your school's computer. This will bypass any restrictions that only work when you're connected to the school network. The only catch is that it does not bypass the restrictions set, not on the school WiFi, but on the computer itself. It works better than a VPN most of the time, but it doesn't remove all of the terrible spyware or the really horrible sites like xhampster. I can't imagine anyone going on xhampster. The only good thing in my school is that it tells you what teacher is spying on your PC in real-time but I doubt that is in anyone else's school. This is taking it's place at C tier!



Virtual machines

We are talking about virtual machines! Now this is a good one! A virtual machine is a tiny bit like dualbooting. It essentially runs an operating system as a windows or mac application inside of your existing operating system. It's basically running a second operating system inside a window. However, you do need enough RAM, CPU power and sometimes administrator access for it to work which makes it super difficult to run on heavily managed school computers. I'm going to put this in B tier because if you could get this working, it will actually be a problem.



Asking IT

This one isn't a joke! This can work if you have an actual educational reason to legitimately access a website but if it's unrelated to school and learning, IT are obviously going to say no. So this is definitely going to be unranked. I've had people ask the teacher or IT if they can unblock a certain website and it's always been either that they cannot do that or just straight up no.



Extentions

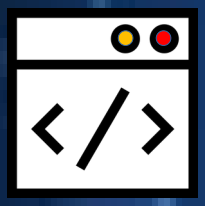
Basically there are these small extensions on the chrome web store and sometimes they work sometimes they won't. Some of them are decent but the issue is that 90% of the time they're blocked. For some reason, all of my friends' schools have the chrome web store unblocked on either the art or library computers. There are 3rd party extension stores which aren't popular so they aren't blocked and I haven't tried on there. However, it is easy for IT to remove the extension but it probably would work for a while so I'm going to put this in D tier.

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USB stick

Now I have some things to say about this. First we will be talking about dual booting and then we will be talking about storage. It is pretty much identical to an external SSD, just a bit slower but I never notice a difference. It is smaller and more compact, unlike an SSD. I've been saying this a lot but the best Linux distros to not get caught are Winux for w11 and linuxfx 10.5 for w10. Now for storage. There is this website cal GOG games and they sell games with offline download installers with their aim to make you own your games again. If you want to pirate the games and play for free, you can use GOG unlocked. If you put these installer files on a USB stick and plug it into the school PC, 99% of the time it will work and install the game. This is by far the best option if you want full control of your school computer.



Inspect Element

Inspect Element allows you to temporarily modify the code of a web page. It's fun but it doesn't really allow you to unblock anything. The JavaScript section can cross over here because it is almost the same. The best thing I used it for was hacking an educational game to change one of the default preset usernames. It's not that good. It is straight F tier. Just like Replit, in my old school even more people be like "Can't you just Inspect element?" and I would be so annoyed because that's just not how it works. In some newer computers, you can't even inspect element which I thought was ridiculous! But I get it I guess… At least it will stop all of the F12 gossip.



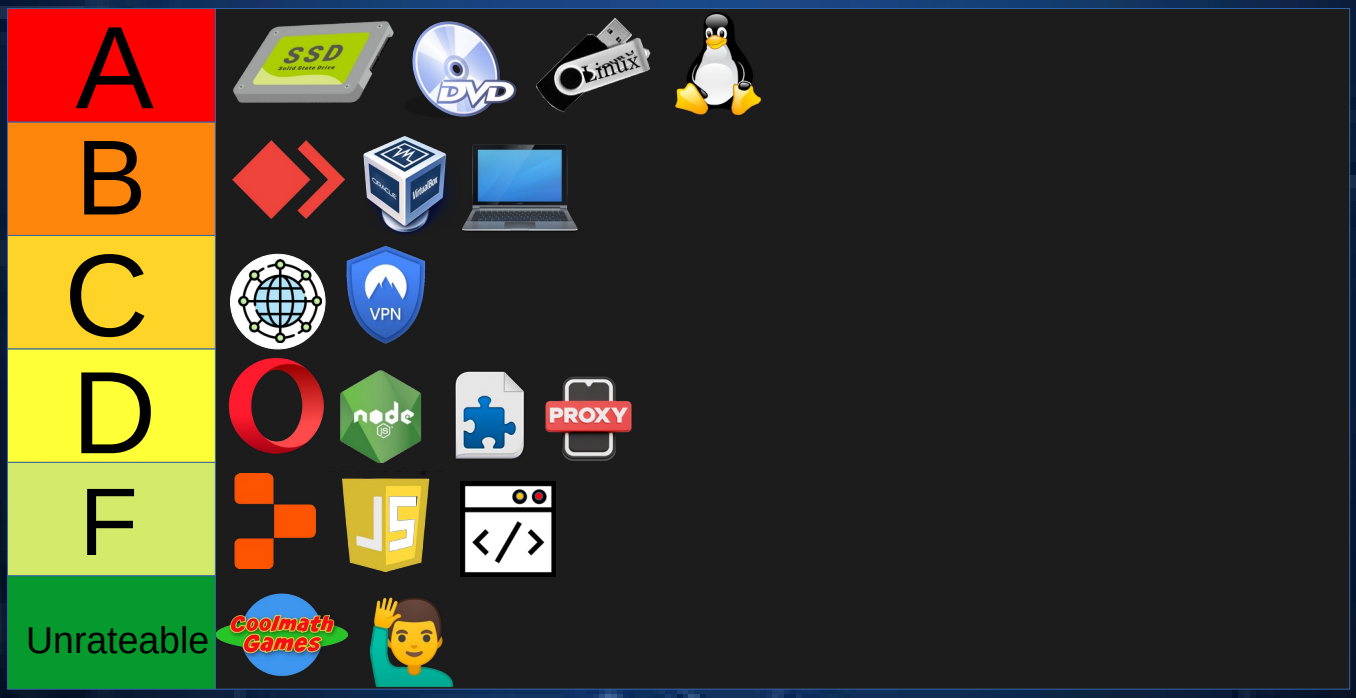
Bringing your own laptop

If your school uses laptops and you have an identical laptop at home, this is a really good idea! Not everyone has a laptop at home so this won't be a good idea any more so it's going to be in B tier.

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Web PROXY

If it is a self-hosted proxy, it would go in the B tier because it basically does the same thing as an Alternate Network. Public proxys are convenient because there is almost nothing to set up but they're the easiest for the schools to discover and block so it's impossible to rate this fairly. They can work surprisingly well for a while but they will be taken down eventually. So it's going to be in D tier. It's not bad but you're going to have issues.



Now I've made this into a nice table if you've forgotten any of the ratings. This feature took forever to make! The image sources are on the next page.

Web & image sources

Unblock your school computer header background – unsplash (https://unsplash.com/photos/a-blue-background-with-lines-and-dots-xuTJZ7uD7PI)

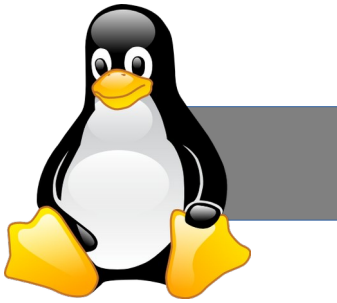
Feature background front cover – istock (https://www.istockphoto.com/vector/double-abstract-green-technology-wave-flow-of-particles-big-data-transfer-gm1667448660-535522648)

The dark blue background makes the white text readable – Vecteezy (https://static.vecteezy.com/system/resources/thumbnails/009/750/414/small/hi-tech-digital-circuit-board-futuristic-ai-pad-and-electrical-lines-connected-on-blue-lighting-background-vector.jpg)

This feature is inspired by the YouTube video I Ranked Every Way to Unblock a School Laptop by Phoxphor.

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Linux alternatives to Mac and Windows apps



Now is the perfect time to start switching over to Linux. There have been Linux distributions that look identical to windows for almost 20 years now, so now is the perfect time to do it! But the problem with all of this is that there are barely any applications that have support for Windows, Mac AND Linux, which is terrible, so today, this article will guide you with the best and correct alternatives for these applications so you don't have to spend hours researching!

Microsoft Office --> LibreOffice

If you are looking for a free alternative to Microsoft Office, then LibreOffice is one of the best options available on Linux. It includes Writer for documents, Calc for spreadsheets and Impress for presentations, meaning you can do almost everything you would normally do with Microsoft Office. The interface is slightly different, but it is still fairly easy to learn. LibreOffice can also open and save many Microsoft Office file formats, so you can continue working with documents made on Windows without needing to buy Microsoft Office.





LibreOffice®

MS Paint/Paint.net --> Photopea

If you need only to edit photos, there are several alternatives to Paint on Linux. However, you will not find a program as easy to use as Paint. The site Photopea .org is a good alternative because it works directly in the browser without the need to download and install the program. This utility has many features such as layers, crop, resize, filters, text, and much more. Photopea also allows you to open Photoshop files to make more complex edits. However, if you only want to make simple drawings, it is better to use a simpler program.





Photoshop --> Virtual Machine

These are all of the alternatives we could find. Unfortunately, even though there are Linux alternatives to Adobe Photoshop, the apps do not have the advanced editing features of Photoshop. The only alternative we could find is Photopea but it is not advanced enough to be worthy. However, if you do just want to paint basic stuff, then you should go to photopea or if you are not switching to Linux, just use paint.net. The only and the best way to get Photoshop on Linux is to run a virtual machine of Windows 10/11 and download it that way.





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Coming (hopefully) 1st November